Aftermath

By Jessica Blank and Erik Jensen

Pacing of this selection should be slow "Shell-shocked" – The American missiles were completely unexpected by the citizens of Iraq.

INTRODUCTION

March 20, 2003 - American missiles hit the Iraqi capital, Baghdad, signaling the start of the US-led campaign to topple Saddam Hussein. President George W. Bush called the war in Iraq "one of the swiftest and most humane military campaigns in history." Yet thousands of Iraqi civilians were killed or injured during the three weeks of fighting from the first air strikes on March 20 to April 9, 2003, when Baghdad fell to U.S.-led Coalition forces.

As Americans watched the war unfold on television, the human factor of the Iraqi people became lost. This selection brings voice to two average citizens who were trapped in the war zone of Baghdad in 2003: Shahid, a young translator in his mid-twenties and Basima, a wife and mother. Both were overwhelmed in the . . .

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SHAHID: Under Saddam, it's not like we all walked down the streets of Baghdad in grey suits, like, grim faces, heads hanging down. We're Iraqis, we're not Russians. But we knew where the red lines were. We knew what would upset who. . We know that if we kept our nose off politics, if we didn't insult Saddam, then: "happily ever after" We had some space.

BASIMA: *(Lights up on Basima, early thirties, sweet and a big shy. A loose scarf over her hair. She wears a cross)*

Anee Basima Jabar / Ummi hinana, hem, bes ma tehchi / My mother doesn't want to come out – Her brain injury, you know. She made us some coffee, though. Unless you'd prefer – (Smiles) Okay. So, we've been in Jordan almost two years now.

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Back in Iraq, growing up, our life was sweet: big house, school, ya3ni, mother, father, kids, normal everyday things. Once, when my father was at work, my sister and I called and said the house is on fire, hurry up, come home! And he "buh buh buh buh" comes home like ***he's*** on fire, and he says, "There's nothing wrong with the house! What have I told you about lying?" My sister and I said, "We just missed you." Many fathers would get angry, but ours just laughed.

The best was Christmas. Even a month before, we would be getting the tree ready. Lights, ornaments, teddy bears, Papa Noel. In the morning all our cousins would come – so many. Second cousins, third cousins, fourth cousins. And, you know, one of those cousins I wound up marrying. *(Confiding)* We had a -- *(To Shahid)* ***Il hub il awal***

SHAHID: *Oh, ah, um – (to us) A Crush*

BASIMA: *(Nods)* – since childhood. Sometimes he'd come by: "I saw this girl and I saw this other girl." I'd get so jealous that I'd break things in the house! During the engagement, that whole year you can't imagine all the things I broke because of him. Should I show you guys his picture to see? *(Pulls a picture from an envelope)* I was pregnant in this picture. *(Looks at the photo)* He's got a beautiful face, eh?

SHAHID: Saddam's religion was loyalty. He killed many many people because of this. He even killed his own brother-n-law when he opposed him. If Saddam appeared on TV, the father couldn't say anything bad, because his son might say something in school. See under Saddam, the father was even afraid of his own son. Everyone was watching everyone. And everyone knew he was being watched

BASIMA: I think – most Americans don't know what a bomb sounds like. You don't feel your eardrums, from the sound, ya3ni. Every explosion we thought the world would crumble on top of us. Every strike . . . is an earthquake. For nine days,

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the whole family hid out in one room with no windows. And then, when we finally went out again – *(Beat To Shahid)* ***Mah agdar awsuf shikilha, reehatha, goolelhum***, *(I can't describe what it looked like, the smell)* tell them, okay –

SHAHID: ***Ma tigdareen tuwasifeen il*** – *(You want me to describe the?) (In English)* Okay. *(To us)* You know, the streets were full of corpses. People couldn't stand the stench, so they started to dig, right in the dirt, wherever they could, to bury people wherever they were laying. You know, the Iran-Iraq War, the Kuwait War, they weren't in the cities; men went away to fight. It was "over there." But here – the smell – *(Beat)* You don't get that from TV.

Imagine: Iraq has been isolated for decades, it's the first time most Iraqis see foreigners. People started coming to Baghdad from all over the world: not just soldiers, ya3ni: journalists, humanitarians, et cetera.

BASIMA: In the beginning, we would find letters in the garden. They would say, "This is an Islamic country. You Christians are not welcome here." It's in an envelope, sometimes typed, sometimes handwritten. No name, no signature, but there's a bullet with it.

But, ***ya3ni,*** threatening letters were so widespread at the time. You know, this was normal. And we couldn't flee like, come to Jordan, or Syria, or something – you can't just pick up the pieces and do that. I mean, we're seven of us and I'm pregnant.

We didn't think that it would get to the point of . . . *(She trails off)*

SHAHID: Me, personally I became a refugee at the end of 2005. I left after I was kidnapped by the police. Don't be nervous; not American police – Iraqi police. Still nervous? *(Beat)* Okay, "Iraqi police," let me explain. When the American army first cam, they dismantled all the Iraqi army and police, leaving a void. Then, they appointed a governing council made of two parties that had been outlawed by Saddam. So these parties put their militias in uniform, and they

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called them the "Iraqi Police." If they want, they could take you, beat you, whatever. All using the police uniform and official mechanisms. (Beat) So, there are two kinds of gangs in Iraq; there are non-governmental gangs and there are governmental gangs.

You know not everybody got along all the time. Saddam had exploited these – undercurrents, between people, for twenty-five years. And the Americans – they don't understand all these splits: Sunni, Shi'a, Jewish, Christian, Kurd.

Our humanity is drifting from their humanity in four or five different directions. So far that you can't reach either side. If it means your life, at some point, you can't keep a foot on both banks. Everyone's pulling at you to make a choice: this side, that side, or you drown *(Pause)* This seems to me an unnatural way to live.

BASIMA: I gave birth in July. Our first child. And when he was two months old, it came time for us to get him vaccinations. *(Long beat)* So – we were on the way to the doctor's with the baby. Everyone came in the car, me and my husband and my mother and my son and my sister – because my sister was just seventeen, we couldn't leave her alone in the house, someone, the militias . . . could come into the house and . . . *(She can't say it)* . . and hurt her.

In the car, we were all just happy with the baby and fussing, would this vaccination go okay, would he cry, would he feel better.

And then, all of a sudden – ya3ni, sound, and heat, lots of heat. And the smell of burnt hair and flesh. And pain. The car shook, hard, and right away I lost my sight.

I don't know how I got out of the car. I couldn't see. The thing I could hear most was the sound of my husband's voice. I just followed the sound back to him.

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He wanted to get out of the car but his legs were fused to the seat. I tried to get him out, but he was heavy, I couldn't I couldn't. I felt the fire start to eat at my hands I tried to get him out, I tried, but I ***couldn't*** *(Beat)* So I left. I called for whoever could help me. I was yelling at the top of my lungs. But there wasn't any person, there wasn't anybody. It was as if the world had ended.

And then another explosion, and screaming and yelling. And then my husband's voice disappears.

I hear bullets from every direction. And I'm barefoot, and I can't see and I don't know what to do so I just sit down. There's nobody there. Nobody nobody. It is as if Baghdad has been emptied of people.

Of course, you know, this accident was on television. They showed me like – my blouse was open. My clothes were burned off. And I'm asking, what happened where's my husband, my son, my mother, my sister. One Muslim guy, do you know what he says to me? He says *(Clearly mocking)* "They went to Allah."

From ten-thirty 'til twelve-thirty I was in the street. After two hours I heard the blades of a helicopter. Americans came, they were speaking English. They were checking out what the car bomb was. It was a long time 'til they came to me. I was secondary. But whatever I can say about the . . . accident wouldn't be enough. *(she needs a break)*

SHAHID: Iraq had been at war, more or less, for the last twenty-five years. With Iran, with Kuwait, with Saddam, the sanctions, now . . . daily bombings. Daily. Everyone in the county has traumatic stress. It's normal IF everyone has the problem, it's not really a problem, is it? It's just life.

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BASIMA: At the hospital, I keep asking where my family is. Because the guy in the street that said they "Went to Allah," he was kind of talking out of his ass, you know.

When I would regain consciousness, I felt myself sticking to the sheets. I didn't have any skin. I was naked, I didn't have clothes on. I would find pieces of shrapnel in the bed. They came out when I was sleeping, ***ya3ni?*** My whole body was shrapnel. My hands, my shoulders, my face.

This eye has a piece of metal in it still, but this one they fixed. So I would go into the bathroom and catch myself in the mirror. And I would be afraid of my own face

When I would wake up I would ask my father, how is everyone? Where are they? What's the news? He would say, "They're fine. Your mom's right next to you, you see her, right there." He would laugh and tell stories, keep me happy. He'd say –

SHAHID: ***"Zoujich, ibnich wa ukhtich – Il Amrikan akhtouhum ila mustashfa ahsan / Sema3tee il Helicopter."***

BASIMA: *(Overlapping)* "Your husband, your son and your sister – the Americans took them to a better hospital. You heard the helicopter. . . Real bullshit, ***ya3ni***.

After a while, I stopped asking, so I could just stay in the story he was telling me. But after a month and a half I couldn't take it anymore. I needed to know.

My father was holding it all so it wouldn't show, because I was getting my strength from him. But the second I found out the truth – my sister, my husband, my baby – my father broke down. I don't blame my father, though. I was the one what wanted him to lie to me.

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Ya3ni when it's Christmas now I remember how we used to be, and it – *(Beat)* I don't celebrate anymore. We have left everything behind: our kings, our stories, our possessions, our wealth. I have been – we have been – ***inthulmat*** -?

SHAHID: Darkened

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AWARD HISTORY

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**ya3ni – an Iraqi term meaning "like" – a filler word.*

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